official website' by October 2012 (2015, p. 156). In fact, as part of their campaign strategy, PTI 'mobilized a twenty-five-member social media team comprised of volunteers from around the world to keep the party's online platform buzzing', a move that pushed other political parties to also use online platforms more effectively (2015). Ironically, Yusaf also notes how Pervez Musharraf after being ousted from power boasted about 'his social media following – 825,000 Facebook "likes" in March 2013' as an indicator of his popularity, 'far more than Khan's' (2015, p. 160). Despite the fact that PTI won seats in KP, a province where mobile and internet penetration had yet to gain momentum, the party's presence on social media nonetheless was important in gaining local and international traction, where 'Khan was better able to position himself as a political outsider and revolutionary' (2015, p. 157).

However, any discussion on the use of social media in Pakistan needs to first examine the nature of these 'users'. Khan and Nisbet's (2016) research related to 'online censorship' that included 3,720 Pakistani internet users, revealed that 'heavy internet users in Pakistan', that is those 'who use the internet every day', are predominantly 'very young (72% under 30 years of age), largely male (59%), and highly educated (72% with at least some university schooling)' (also see Durrani et al. 2015). Seventy-seven per cent of all internet users accessed social media websites such as Facebook and Twitter. For the participants in the 2015–16 survey the majority used social media sites, where Facebook was more popular than Twitter.[8]

However, social media can also be used as a mechanism of surveillance. This surveillance can range from strategies developed to gauge consumer behaviour and preference based on 'a complex set of data collection, tracking, and targeting systems that monitor and monetize individual users' behaviors as well as their interactions with friends and acquaintances' (Montgomery 2015, p. 773; also evident in the Facebook's Cambridge Analytica scandal), or to gauge the potential of online political dissent that can translate into real-world activism, thereby providing an opportunity to crack down on such activity before it is implemented offline (Rahimi 2011). According to a Freedom House (2017) report Pakistan's 'Freedom on the Net' status is 'not free'; the country's level of internet openness is ranked at 71 out of 100, and that place has fallen from 2016 when it was 69 out of 100.[9] Yusaf highlights how 'in the years following the liberalization of broadcast media, the SPR, the public relations wing of the Pakistan army, was expanded to comprise separate wings to monitor and engage with print media, FM radio, private television channels, and social media outlets such as Facebook and Twitter' (Yusaf 2015, p. 162). By 2016 online dissent and